ReviseSociology

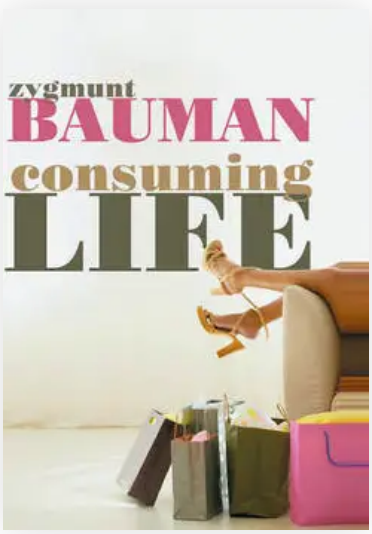
# Zygmunt Bauman's Consuming Life (2007): Chapter One

By Karl Thompson / January 23, 2017

Table of Contents

Last Updated on July 12, 2025 by Karl Thompson

In Consuming Life Bauman outlines the key features of a consumer-capitalist society. The main way in which this society induces people to consume, and keep capitalism going, is to make people feel unhappy and dissatisfied thus making them want to consume more in a flawed attempt to be less miserable.




I use paraphrasing heavily below, so a lot of this is Bauman's own words, just cut down a lot and also simplified in places. Love the guy's literary style but it doesn't always result in accessibility. The chapter is broken up into about nine sub sections, but I've knitted a few of the ideas together below to condense these into.

## The basic characteristics of consumer society

The chapter only briefly deals with consumption – which is part of all societies – at the beginning, the remaining 90% deals with consumerism, or the unique features of the consumer society, which emerges with the decline of the society of producers some years after WW2.

Consumerism describes that society in which wanting has become the principal propelling and operating force which coordinates systemic reproduction, social integration, social stratification and the formation of identity and life-policies.

In consumer society wanting, desiring and longing needs to be, just as labour capacity was in the producers' society, detached ('alienated') from individuals and recycled/reified into an extraneous force.

In the previous society of producers desires were always, after deferred gratification, eventually meant to be satisfied.Moreover, the function of objects of consumption, once acquired, was to provided a sense of durability and long-term security. In contrast, the consumer society

associates happiness with an ever rising volume and intensity of desires, which imply in turn prompt use and speedy replacement of the objects intended and hoped to gratify them.

### Characteristics of the consumer society

1. An instability of desires and insatiability of needs – Consumer society thrives when we want more and when those wants have a high turnover rate – i.e when the goods we buy provide satisfaction for a limited time period only.
2. The desire for Immediate gratification – which has given rise to a 'Nowist culture' – or a curiously hurried life. However, because today's products only have a limited life span and a stigma once its date is reached the motive to hurry is only partly the urge to acquire and collect, the most pressing need is to discard and replace.
3. Pointillist time – Time is experienced as 'broken up, or even pulverised, into a multitude of 'eternal instants' episodes which are not connected to each other. Bauman suggests that these episodes are like 'Big bangs' – they are pregnant with possibilities of magnficent things happening, however these moments rarely live up to their promise and it is in fact the excess of promises which counters each promise not lived up to.

## How consumer society effects our worldview

In the consumerist economy product innovations grow at an exponential rate and there is increasing competition for attention. This results in a flood of information which we cannot cope with which manifests itself in vertical stacking (think multiple windows on the go at the same time).

Images of 'linear time' and 'progress' are among the most prominent victims of the information flood: when growing amounts of information are distributed at growing speed, it becomes increasingly difficult to create narratives, orders, developmental sequences. The fragments threaten to become hegemonic.

This in turn has consequences for the ways we relate to knowledge, work and lifestyle in a wide sense.

**Firstly** this results in a **blase attitude toward knowledge** – the essence of which is the blunting of discrimination

**Secondly** it results in **melancholy** – To be 'melancholic' is 'to sense the infinity of connection, but be hooked up to nothing' – a disturbance resulting from the fatal encounter between the obligation and compulsion to choose and the inability to choose. *(This seems like an evolution of the concept of **anomie**)*

The crucial skill in information society consists in protecting oneself against the 99.99 per cent of the information offered that one does not want.

## The consumer society fails to make us happy

The society of consumers stands and falls by the happiness of its members

It is, in fact, the only society in human history to promise happiness in earthly life, and happiness here and now and in every successive now – also the only society which refrains from legitimising unhappiness.

However, judged by its own standards it is woefully unsuccessful at increasing happiness.

Bauman now draws on research carried out by Richard Layard to remind us that once average income rises above approximately $20K per head then there is no evidence whatsoever that further growth in the volume of consumption results in a greater number of people reporting that they 'feel happy'.

In fact a consumption-oriented economy actively promotes disaffection, saps confidence and deepens the sentiment of insecurity, becoming itself a source of the ambient fear it promises to cure or disperse.

While consumer society rests its case on the promise to gratify human desires, the promise of satisfaction remains seductive only as long as the desire stays ungratified. *Clever!*

A low threshold for dreams, easy access to sufficient goods to reach that threshold, and a belief in objective limits to 'genuine' needs and 'realistic' desires: these are the most fearsome adversaries of the consumer-oriented economy.

## Consumer society creates perpetual unhappiness

Necessary strategies to maintain this involve hyping a product to the hilt and then soon after denigrating it and creating goods and services such that they require further purchases to be made – so that consumption becomes a compulsion, an addiction and shoppers are encouraged to find solutions to their problems only in the shopping malls.

The realm of hypocrisy stretching between popular beliefs and the realities of consumers' lives is a necessary condition of a properly functioning society of consumers.

In addition to being an economics of excess and waste, consumerism is also an economics of deception.

## Individualised life-strategies

**Individualised life strategies are the principle means whereby consumer society neutralises dissent**

The society of consumers has developed, to an unprecedented degree, the capacity to absorb all and any dissent. It does this through a process which Thomas Mathiesen has recently described as 'silent silencing'

In other words all ideas threatening to the existing order are integrated into it.

The principle means whereby this is done is through individualisation – whereby individual life strategies become the route to Utopia to only be enjoyed by the individual – changing lifestyle, not society.

To follow the metaphor used by schoolboy Karl Marx, those visions are attracted like moths to the lights of domestic lamps rather than to the glare of the universal sun now hidden beyond the horizon.

The possibility of populating the world with more caring people and inducing people to care more does not figure in the panoramas painted in the consumerist utopia.

The privatized utopias of the cowboys and cowgirls of the consumerist era show instead vastly expanded 'free space' (free for myself, of course); a kind of empty space of which the liquid modern consumer, bent on solo performances and only on solo performances, always needs more and never has enough.

Lifestyle strategies smack of adiaphorisation – removing sense of moral responsibility for others.

### Related Posts

Consuming Life Chapter Two: The Society of Consumers.

To explore more social theories please see my sociological theories page.

### Reference

**Bauman, Z.** (2007). *Consuming Life*. Cambridge: Polity Press. ISBN: 9780745640020.

You can use the search bar there to look up "Consuming Life Zygmunt Bauman" directly.

←PREVIOUS
Gender Equality in Saudi Arabia

NEXT →
Summary of Liquid Modernity – Chapter Two – I...

### Leave a Reply

Write a comment...

Comment

This site uses Akismet to reduce spam. Learn how your comment data is processed.

Copyright © 2026 ReviseSociology | Powered by Astra WordPress Theme